something—whether it was needed or not. The result: often a blurring of my original intentions.

Because arms reduction was so important, I decided in this instance to switch to a more hands-on approach—without help from the bureaucrats.

At a National Security Council meeting in early March, I announced that I had decided to draft a response to Chernenko without asking input from the bureaucracy. From then on, I would consult only with a small group—George Bush, George Shultz, Cap Weinberger, and Bud McFarlane, my national security advisor, in the National Security Planning Group to determine whether we could develop a long-range plan that offered the Russians a series of small steps, and showed that we were sincere about wanting to improve relations as a prelude to a summit and hoped they were, too. These entries from my diary in March summarized some of the developments that were happening then:

> *March 2*
>
> I'm convinced the time has come for me to meet with Chernenko along about July 1. We're going to start with some ministerial level meetings on a number of substantive matters that have been on ice since the KAL 007 shoot down.

> *March 5*
>
> Helmut Kohl, West German chancellor, arrived. We had a good meeting and lunch. He confirmed my belief that the Soviets are motivated at least in part by insecurity and a suspicion that we and our allies mean them harm. They still preserve the tank traps and barbed wire that show how close the Germans got to Moscow before they were stopped. He too thinks I should meet Chernenko.